■■ Sustainable Materials & Market Intelligence Briefing

Monday, 12 October 2026 — prepared for Amy, KAESA (Seoul)

1. The material KAESA actually uses just got its hardest test yet

One item today reaches straight into your product line, and it is not a regulation.

A durability assessment of Desserto cactus leather — the nopal-cactus material family most commonly specified for plant-based bags — published 30 September concluded that it performs like a refined coated textile, not a lifetime material. The reason is compositional. Desserto is not pressed cactus biomass; it is a composite of processed nopal cactus with polyurethane and other binders, so it is only partially bio-based and only partially biodegradable. Under light use — clutches, card holders — the surface holds up. Under repeated flexing at handle, strap and zipper corners on large totes, the polyurethane-rich top layer can develop micro-cracking and dull patches. It does not develop patina, because there is no collagen fibre network to deepen.

Your own product page already says the honest version of this. That is exactly right, and worth protecting.

Two things follow. First, the durability finding argues for your compartment and reinforcement design, not against the material — keeping loads off high-flex corners is a decision you control. Second, it sharpens a claim risk. "Vegan leather" reads to EU enforcers as a material-composition claim, and it is defensible. But "plant-based," "biodegradable" and "eco-friendly" used about the whole bag are now generic claims under the EmpCo Directive — in force across all Member States since 27 September 2026, with no transition period — unless you can demonstrate recognised excellent environmental performance. In practice that means an EU Ecolabel or an officially recognised EN ISO 14024 type I ecolabel. A Life Cycle Assessment, however careful, does not clear that bar. Germany and Austria also let competitors seek injunctions in days.

Sources:

https://www.luxury-leather-good.com/cactus-leather-at-three-checking-in-on-desserto-and-the-plant-based-promise
https://www.lw.com/en/insights/eu-empowering-consumers-directive-new-rules-on-green-claims-apply-from-27-september-2026
https://envrt.com/insights/empco-banned-environmental-claims-fashion

2. Materials & Innovation

- **Desserto's certified biobased numbers are the useful part** — The company holds the USDA Certified Biobased Product label: its **BIO+ range is certified at 65% biobased content**, with a 90% biobased line now offered. It also launched Chili Leather in September, a limited harvest-linked material built on Zacatecas guajillo chili as a natural pigment. A certified biobased percentage is a claim that survives an audit; "plant-based" is not. Ask your supplier for theirs.

https://desserto.com.mx/certified-biobased
https://the-ethos.co/desserto-bottles-a-mexican-chili-harvest-into-its-boldest-leather-yet/

- **Textile-to-textile recycling moved to contracted volume** — Primark signed its first multi-year offtake with Circ, whose solvent process separates polycotton blends and recovers both polyester and cellulose. No tonnage, pricing or delivery dates were disclosed, and Circ's facility is still in development.

https://www.thefabricbrief.com/articles/primark-signs-first-multi-year-offtake-with-circ-for-recycled-polyester-952047e7

- **Plant-based elastane hit commercial scale — Lycra, 70% bio-based** — A 2026 Ramboll life cycle assessment found up to **45% lower carbon footprint** versus conventional Lycra, using dent corn grown primarily in Iowa to replace petroleum-derived PTMEG. Caveat: textile-to-textile spandex

recycling remains at pilot stage with no commercial timeline. The fibre is available now; the recycled version is not.

https://www.thefabricbrief.com/articles/lycra-hits-commercial-scale-on-70-plant-based-spandex-cuts-carbon-45-77e2e7ac

- **Avantium produced its first commercial batch of FDCA** — 28 September, Delfzijl, Netherlands: the world's first commercial-scale FDCA plant. PEF is a plant-based, recyclable polyester alternative with a CO■ barrier roughly 16× better than PET. **PANGAIA and Kvadrat hold textile offtake agreements.** Full capacity is expected over 12–24 months. For linings and interior structures, this is the first credible non-fossil polyester at industrial scale.

https://newsroom.avantium.com/avantium-announces-the-start-up-of-its-flagship-plant-with-the-first-batch-of-fdca-produced/
https://avantium.com/products-technologies/pef-and-fdca/

- **Recycled cotton's real ceiling: about 10%** — Fashion for Good's Cotton Reloop Matrix Project (announced 6 October) notes that mechanical recycling loses 45–50% of input as short fibres, which is why most commercial recycled cotton yarns cap near 10% recycled content. The project will run 10 demonstrator fabrics and publish an open-source spinning SOP. The framing to adopt internally: **fit for purpose, not virgin parity.**

https://textileworldasia.com/textile-world-asia/2026/10/fashion-for-good-launches-the-cotton-reloop-matrix-project-to-unlock-commercial-scale-for-recycled-cotton/

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3. Policy & Regulation

- **EUDR: leather came out of scope on 18 September 2026** — Commission Delegated Regulation (EU) 2026/2102 removed cattle hides, skins and leather (CN ex 4101, 4104, 4107) from Annex I, with no transition period. Finished leather goods — handbags, belts, wallets — were never listed at all. Read this carefully before relaxing: the Commission's own estimate put leather at up to 17% of EU-import deforestation risk, and it mandated a review of leather's status in **2030**. That is a three-year window, not a permanent exemption.

https://environment.ec.europa.eu/news/commission-updates-product-scope-and-tools-support-eudr-2026-07-13_en
https://eudrcheck.co.uk/guides/eudr-annex-i-changes-2026-2102

- **Textile EPR: fees by April 2028** — Directive (EU) 2025/1892 entered into force 17 October 2025. Member States must transpose by 17 June 2027 and **establish textile and footwear EPR schemes by 17 April 2028**, with producers paying a fee per product placed on the market. The scope explicitly includes "clothing and accessories" — bags included — and micro-enterprises get one additional year. Separately, all separately collected textiles are now legally classified as waste until professionally sorted as fit for re-use.

https://oeil.europarl.europa.eu/oeil/en/document-summary?id=1845495
https://environment.ec.europa.eu/news/revised-waste-framework-directive-enters-force-2025-10-16_en

- **ESPR textile delegated act: adoption Q3–Q4 2027, DPP registry already live** — The DPP Registry became operational on **20 July 2026**, with the framework Implementing Act and six DPP standards established the same month. Economic operators get at least 18 months after adoption. Textile DPP data may include fibre composition, origin, repair information and end-of-life handling. No draft delegated act has been published yet — the JRC preparatory study is still the technical foundation.

https://single-market-economy.ec.europa.eu/single-market/digital-product-passport_en
https://traceable.digital/regulatory-update/espr-textiles-preparatory-study-third-milestone/

- **EmpCo enforcement is national and unevenly transposed** — The Commission opened infringement procedures against 20 Member States on 28 May 2026 for missing the 27 March transposition deadline. Its Q&A does allow remediation for existing stock — sticker corrections, or additional information at point of sale. Online claims get far less leniency than packaging, because they are cheap to fix. Note that the Green Claims Directive remains a proposal, not law; EmpCo is what applies.

https://www.debevoise.com/insights/publications/2026/07/preparing-for-the-empowering-consumers-for-the

- **The EU destruction ban is already live** — Since 19 July 2026, large enterprises are prohibited from destroying unsold apparel, accessories and footwear; medium-sized enterprises follow from 19 July 2030, and micro and small enterprises are exempt. Note that recycling counts as destruction here, so sending stock to a recycler is not automatically compliant. Worth knowing even as an SME: any European retail partner you sell through is already bound by it.

https://environment.ec.europa.eu/news/ban-destruction-unsold-clothes-and-shoes-enters-application-2026-07-17_en
https://www.hlc.com/en/publications/stop-the-destruction-of-textiles-how-compliance-changes-from-19-july-2026

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4. Market Intelligence

- **Textile Exchange Materials Market Report 2026 — first end-use breakdown, bags included** — Published 22 September, 13th edition. For the first time it estimates global raw material production by end use, with **bags** as a separate category alongside apparel, footwear and home textiles. This is the number set your buyers and any future investor will quote at you. The accompanying 2026 Materials Benchmark drew on 384 brands and retailers, and from 2027 annual reporting becomes mandatory for Action Cohort members.

https://textileexchange.org/knowledge-center/reports/materials-market-report-2026/

- **Textile Exchange Conference runs this week — Vancouver, 12–16 October** — Today is day one, themed "The Implementation Era." The stated agenda is converting readiness into action: reporting, data sharing, sourcing verified materials. Lycra presents Renewable Lycra and its pilot spandex recycling at stand 18, and expects offtake conversations. If you want one commercially available material upgrade this quarter, that floor is where the supply conversations are happening.

https://textileexchange.org/conference-2026/

- **Future Fabrics Expo: biosynthetics got a dedicated area for the first time** — The Sustainable Angle's move from London to Brussels (24–25 June 2026) put roughly 120–150 exhibitors and over 10,000 certified materials beside the EU institutions, co-located with the Textiles Recycling Expo. Named themes: algae feedstocks, bacterial and digitally-dyed denim, sugarcane bio-elastane, mycelium leather alternatives, captured-CO■ fibres. The honest assessment from the floor: the science is largely in hand; volume and cost are the constraint. Bolt Threads raised over US$300 million before pausing Mylo in 2023.

https://wwd.com/sustainability/innovation/future-fabrics-expo-post-petro-fashion-economy-brussels-1239032658/
https://www.everestgrp.com/blogs/future-fabrics-expo-2026-what-the-innovators-showed-and-what-the-teaches-them-next/

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5. For Your Radar

- **Get your biobased percentage in writing, and put it on the page.** EmpCo's generic-claim ban exempts specific ones: "80% recycled content" survives where "eco-friendly" does not. "X% certified biobased content, USDA BioPreferred" is specific and substantiated. This is a one-conversation fix with your material supplier, and it turns your weakest claim into your strongest.

- **The 2030 EUDR review is a planning date, not a footnote.** The Commission stated plainly that excluding leather may relocate rather than eliminate deforestation risk. The industry's answer is voluntary traceability — the European leather sector has developed EN 18199 for minimum traceability levels. If any part of your supply chain touches animal-derived material, three years is how long you have to be able to answer "where did this come from" without being legally required to.

- **Ask suppliers for the full test record, not the headline number.** Rheom Materials' new Shorai Dura upper reports up to 500,000 Bally Flex cycles and 70,000 Martindale revolutions, but published no wet abrasion, colourfastness, tear propagation or tensile strength results. The Martindale figure your cactus

material clears is the number that matters — get it in the spec sheet, at the load and flex profile your bags actually see.

Bottom line

1. **Audit every EU-facing claim this week.** EmpCo has no transition period and digital claims get the least leniency. Replace generic words with specific, substantiated, scoped ones. Start with your material page — the honest "not fully biodegradable" line you already publish is an asset.
2. **Ask suppliers for certified biobased percentages and full test records.** A USDA-certified 65% biobased figure survives an audit. "Plant-based" does not.
3. **Decide your EPR position before 2028, not during it.** Fees land 17 April 2028, micro-enterprises get one extra year, and bags are in scope as accessories. A take-back or repair programme started now becomes a fee-modulation and DPP-readiness asset.

Prepared by Esther — sustainability & materials intelligence for KAESA.

All sources linked inline. Supplier-reported figures are flagged as such; verify test records and certification scope directly with the supplier before specifying or repeating.